



PREPARING FOR A HEALTH CARE APPOINTMENT

Before you left the hospital with your child, you likely set up follow up appointments. Be sure to keep those appointments. Taking your baby or child to their first appointment after hospitalization can feel hectic, especially if you have a new baby. Here are some tips from parents to help you prepare:



HAVE QUESTIONS AND CONCERNS READY

Make a list of questions for your child's doctor including any concerns you have. Most parents question what is "normal" and what isn't. If you have a partner or spouse, ask for their questions too. When at an appointment, it can be easy to forget what you wanted to ask, so having a list prepared will help. Don't be afraid to write the answers too.



TAKE ANOTHER ADULT WITH YOU, IF POSSIBLE

Two sets of ears are often better than one. It can be hard to remember everything the doctor said, so having another adult listener can help with that. Be sure it is someone who will be supportive.



KNOW WHAT IS EXPECTED AND WHAT TESTS ARE INVOLVED

Find out what tests your child will have and what is expected in the appointment before you go. Some tests will involve your child not eating for a period of time, so make sure you follow instructions if your child will need to stop eating and drinking before the appointment.



FILL OUT FORMS AND CHECK INSURANCE COVERAGE

Often, you can fill out medical history and other forms before your appointment. This will save you time and allow you to find answers you need to some questions. Also, check your insurance coverage (if applicable) and make sure you have completed all requirements for coverage.



TAKE MEDICATIONS AND EQUIPMENT WITH YOU

Take medication and equipment with you to appointments. Sometimes appointments go longer than expected or a dose of medication is due during the appointment. Take any medical equipment your child needs. Some non-medical equipment like strollers can help you if your child needs a test in a different location and with coming and going. Things that can soothe or amuse your child like favorite toys can be very helpful during appointments too.



TAKE WATER AND A SNACK

Staying hydrated is important for you and your child. Be sure to bring water (breastmilk or formula for a baby). Also, if you can, pack a snack for you and your child in case you need it. (Be sure to check with a nurse before feeding your child before an appointment or test.)



PREPARE YOUR CHILD

A child life specialist can help you prepare your child for a health care appointment. If there is no child life specialist available, you can ask a nurse if there are any resources to help you prepare your child for an upcoming appointment. Ask other parents who have been through similar situations. There are also children's books that can help you prepare your child.

Preparing for your child's health care appointment can be confusing and overwhelming. You can find more information and helpful tips for preparing yourself and your child for health care appointments at

www.mendedlittlehearts.org

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